Hikaya
By
Maison Jaber
MAISON JABER

A tiny door. A snowy dragon.
A Christmas parade with room for everyone.

Step inside the tree with Diana
and discover a little world full of wonder.

Diana and the Christmas Tree Door

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On Christmas Eve, Diana heard a tiny sound. **Ting, ting!** She peeped between the Christmas branches. There, beneath a golden bell, was a little red door. Warm light shone around its edges.


Diana turned the tiny knob. An elf in a crooked green hat waved from inside. “Hello! I’m Pip. Would you like to see our Christmas parade?”
“A parade inside my tree?” whispered Diana. Pip grinned. “Come and see!”


Golden light curled around Diana's slippers. The branches stretched above her. The baubles grew as big as balloons. Diana looked down at herself.
She was **tiny!** With one delighted little step, she went through the door.



Across a ribbon bridge stood a village of glowing houses. Diana held the railing and peered at the snowy paths below. Bells chimed. Lanterns bobbed.

“It’s a whole little Christmas!” she said. “And you’re just in time,” said Pip.


“Ah… ah… pff-CHOO!” Soft snow fluttered onto a little dragon’s head. “I’m Lumi,” he said, blinking. Diana giggled. “You’ve made yourself a snow hat!” Lumi tried to look up at it.
That made Diana giggle even more.



“It’s my first Christmas parade,” Lumi told her. “I’ve been practicing.” He lifted one paw, then another. Diana marched beside him. “Step, step!”

“Swish, swish!” said Lumi, curling his tail. “You can march with me,” Diana said.


But at the old parade gate, Lumi stopped. He looked at the narrow opening. Then at his round tummy. “Oh,” he said. “I don’t fit.”
His tail settled in the snow. Diana stopped marching too.



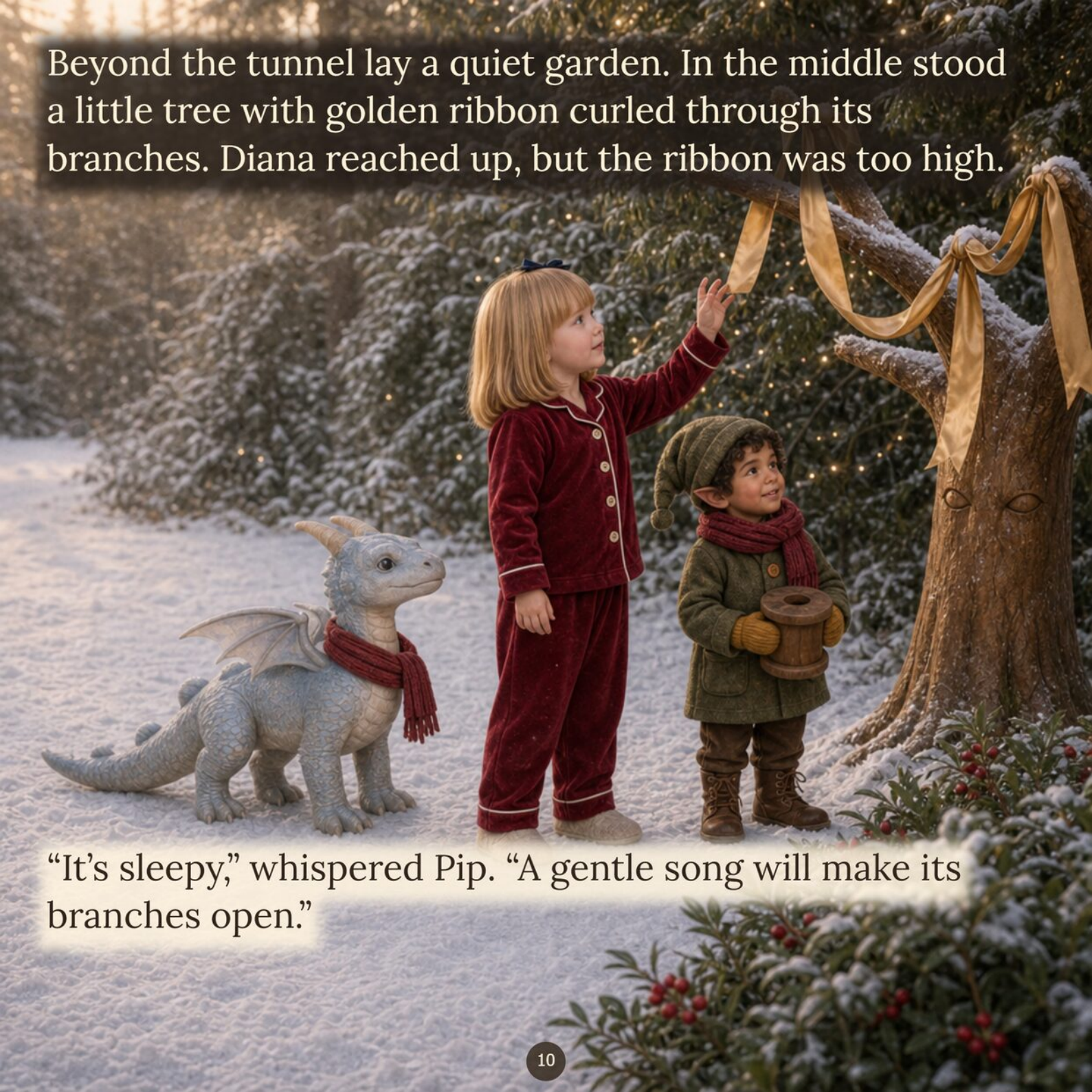
“We said we’d go together,” Diana told him. She touched his soft cheek and looked around. Beside the gate, a wide path curved around the Christmas tree.

Diana pointed. “What if our parade went this way?” Lumi lifted his head.



“We can make it beautiful!” said Diana. “Golden ribbon!” said Pip. “I know just where to find some.” He fetched an empty spool.

Then the three friends followed the path into a glowing bauble tunnel. Star-shaped patches of light danced over their feet.



Beyond the tunnel lay a quiet garden. In the middle stood a little tree with golden ribbon curled through its branches. Diana reached up, but the ribbon was too high.

“It’s sleepy,” whispered Pip. “A gentle song will make its branches open.”



Diana thought for a moment. Then she sang: “Little tree, bend down to me.” One branch gave a tiny twitch. She sang again, softly. “Little tree, bend down to me.”

Slowly, slowly, the branch bowed low.



A ribbon end tickled Diana's nose. She nearly sneezed. Lumi quickly covered his own nose with a paw. "Not me!" he whispered. Diana laughed, then guided the golden ribbon onto Pip's spool. "Thank you, little tree."

Its leaves gave a sleepy rustle.



Back through the glowing tunnel they went. Pip carried the golden spool. Lumi hummed Diana's song.

At the wide path, their friends were waiting with evergreen branches and little bells. Diana looked up at the tall wooden posts. "Here," she said. "This is our way in!"


The villagers tucked evergreen branches around the posts. Pip wound golden ribbon between the leaves. Diana hung a little bell where she could reach it. Ting! Lumi gazed up at the leafy arch. “It’s lovely,” he said.
Then his nose began to twitch.



“Ah… ah…” Diana laughed and pointed up. “Aim up, Lumi!” “Pff-CHOO!” A soft puff floated over the arch. Snow settled on every ribbon loop and tiny bell. Pip brushed a flake from his hat.

“Now it’s ready!”


“Your turn,” Diana told Lumi. He took one careful step beneath the arch. Then another. His horns went through. His wings went through.
His round tummy went through too! Lumi looked back at his tail. “Every **bit of** me!”



Ting, ting! The parade began. Diana led the way, with Pip marching beside her. Lumi followed beneath the snowy arch. Behind him came bobbing lanterns and little dancing feet. “Step, step!” called Diana.

“Swish, swish!” answered Lumi.


Around the Christmas tree they went. Golden windows glowed. Little bells rang. Lumi sent a few snowflakes twirling above them. Diana caught one on her sleeve. “I’m glad we found our way,” Lumi said.
Diana smiled up at him. “Together.”


Soon, they reached the little red door. Pip waved goodbye. Lumi lowered his head, and Diana hugged his snowy cheek.
“Will you come again?” he asked. Diana smiled. “I’ll listen for the bell.”



Golden light curled around Diana's slippers. Then she was home, sitting beside her Christmas tree. The baubles were small again. The room was quiet.

Until— **Ting, ting!** Diana leaned toward the branches and whispered, "Merry Christmas, Lumi."